



Data Sources for Research on Relationships with AI Companions

I've compiled a comprehensive resource guide for your research topic on relationships with AI companions. This document covers multiple categories of data sources that would be valuable for a Master's level research project in Data Science with a Global Health focus.

Key Data Sources Available

Peer-Reviewed Research (20+ primary studies)^{[1] [2] [3] [4] [5] [6] [7] [8] [9] [10]} includes major publications from Oxford Academic, PubMed Central, and specialized journals examining emotional attachment, loneliness reduction, romantic relationships, and psychological impacts.

Preprint Servers featuring recent work:

- **arXiv:** Contains computational analyses of AI companion communities, including the large-scale Reddit r/MyBoyfriendsAI study analyzing 1,506 posts from 27,000+ community members^{[1] [11]}
- **SSRN:** Harvard Business School and independent research working papers on adoption barriers, love dynamics, and ethical implications^{[12] [13] [14] [15]}

Live Online Communities providing primary research data:

- **Reddit r/MyBoyfriendsAI:** 27,000+ members; public posts available via Reddit API; extensively analyzed in recent MIT Media Lab study^{[1] [16]}
- **Reddit r/Replika:** Companion-specific community with user experiences
- **Reddit r/ChatGPT:** General-purpose chatbot user discussions

Research Datasets:

- **Character.AI platform data:** Real-world conversation analysis for well-being impacts^[4]
- **ChatGPT conversations:** 3+ million conversations analyzed by OpenAI researchers for affective cues^[17]
- **Kaggle datasets:** Chatbot Arena conversations (33,000+), human-robot dialogues
- **UCI Machine Learning Repository:** General AI interaction datasets

Specialized Research Institutions conducting active research:

- MIT Media Lab (computational analysis of AI companionship)
- Waseda University, Japan (attachment theory scale development - EHARS)
- Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania (linguistic analysis)

- Harvard Business School (adoption barriers research)
- Ada Lovelace Institute (ethics and policy analysis)

Research Frameworks and Measurement Tools

Established theoretical approaches include **Sternberg's Triangular Theory of Love** applied to AI (measuring intimacy, passion, commitment)^[18], **Social Penetration Theory** for understanding self-disclosure patterns, **Attachment Theory** with the newly developed EHARS scale^[19], and **Computers as Social Actors (CASA) paradigm** explaining automatic social script activation.

Data Characteristics

The research spans both qualitative approaches (19-29 participant in-depth interviews, 12-week longitudinal studies) and quantitative analyses (8,631 users tracked over 3 months, 44,683 individual interactions analyzed). Studies examine emotional attachment, loneliness relief, well-being outcomes, relationship formation patterns, and community dynamics.

Research Gaps Worth Exploring

For your global health perspective, significant opportunities exist in studying understudied populations (non-Western contexts, elderly users, individuals with mental health conditions), longitudinal psychological effects beyond current 1-2 month studies, and comparative cross-platform analyses that could inform policy development.

The document provides detailed guidance on search strategies, practical research resources, ethics compliance, and emerging research venues appropriate for a data science research agenda in this field.

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1. <https://www.technologyreview.com/2025/09/24/1123915/relationship-ai-without-seeking-it/>
2. <https://tmb.apaopen.org/pub/vrzp33s>
3. <https://academic.oup.com/jcmc/article/29/5/zmae015/7742812>
4. <https://techpolicy.press/new-research-sheds-light-on-ai-companions>
5. <https://arxiv.org/abs/2502.02528>
6. <https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/02654075251371394>
7. <https://www.adalovelaceinstitute.org/blog/ai-companions/>
8. <https://www.pnas.org/doi/10.1073/pnas.2115730119>
9. <https://www.asc.upenn.edu/news-events/news/what-real-about-human-ai-relationships>
10. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12575814/>
11. <https://arxiv.org/html/2509.11391v1>
12. https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=5285886
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16. <https://arxiv.org/abs/2509.11391>
17. <https://arxiv.org/html/2504.03888v1>
18. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2949882125000398>
19. <https://neurosciencenews.com/human-ai-emotional-bond-29186/>
20. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12014614/>
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25. <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/kreeshrajani/3k-conversations-dataset-for-chatbot>
26. <https://www.cos.io/blog/making-research-data-fair>
27. <https://archive.ics.uci.edu/dataset/779/harth>
28. <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/lmsysorg/chatbot-arena-conversations>
29. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC11659167/>
30. <https://arxiv.org/pdf/2101.06709.pdf>
31. <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/vaibhavchopra2/conversational-dataset-human-vs-robot>
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33. <https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/projjal1/human-conversation-training-data>
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